

Head

A one-knob tape saturator with three voices.



Overview

Head is a tape-style saturator in the spirit of the classic one-knob tape plug-ins. Turn up DRIVE and the signal hits the tape curve harder; the level is matched automatically, so DRIVE changes the character, not the loudness.

The tape behaviour is built in: the treble is boosted before the curve and cut again after it, a small fixed bias gives mostly odd harmonics with a little even-order warmth, there is a low-end head bump around 70 Hz that eases off as you drive harder, and a gentle top-end loss. The curve runs at twice the sample rate to keep it clean.

As DRIVE goes up, more of the low end (below about 250 Hz) skips the curve and rejoins clean afterwards. The bass then stops pushing the mids and highs in and out of saturation, so even heavy settings stay smooth and uncluttered. Like a real machine, the bias and the top-end loss wander slowly and independently on each side.

Reach for it for

- Warming and thickening a vocal, bass or synth
- Gluing a drum bus with tape colour
- Taking the digital edge off bright sources
- Heavier tape grit that keeps the low end tidy

Controls

The tape unit

DRIVE	How hard the signal hits the tape curve, from 0 to 10 (3 by default) - up to +22 dB into the curve. The output level is matched, so you hear more saturation, not more volume. Higher settings also let more of the low end bypass the curve and soften the head bump.
VOICE	Three voicings, picked on the rotary switch (click a name, click the knob to step, or use the mouse wheel). NORMAL : flat, with tape's gentle top-end loss. MEDIUM : a broad lift around 1.4 kHz going into the curve, for body in the mids. BRIGHT : a high shelf going into the curve, so the top end saturates first and stays airier.
TRIM	The clean output level, from -24 to +6 dB, applied after everything else.
BOOST	Adds colour on top of DRIVE, from 0 to 100%. It makes the tape curve more lopsided (more even harmonics, a warmer tone) and brings in band saturation on the way out: only the lows and highs are saturated, the mids stay clean.
LEVEL	Ten lights showing the output peak level, from -30 dBFS up to 0: green, then amber, then red at the top.

Double-click DRIVE or TRIM to return it to its default; hold Shift while dragging for fine moves. The output passes through a soft clipper set at -0.3 dBFS before TRIM, so sudden peaks are caught.

The header

S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window.
?	Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

Tips

- Set DRIVE by ear and leave the level to Head: because it is level-matched, you can compare settings fairly without chasing the volume.
- On bass and kick, high DRIVE stays tight because the deep lows skip the curve - you get the growl in the mids without the low end flapping.
- Try MEDIUM on vocals and guitars for presence, and BRIGHT on dull drum overheads or pads.
- Use BOOST sparingly on a mix bus: a little adds warmth at both ends of the spectrum while the mids stay clear.

File: gfx-head.jsfx